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Note

'THE PLAY'S THE THING' (*HAMLET* II.II.604)

Towards the end of Act II of *Hamlet* (Q1, 1603),[1] the First Player of the visiting troupe agrees, upon Hamlet's request, that the company will perform 'The Murder of Gonzago', with an inserted speech 'of some dozen or sixteen lines' (II.ii.541) composed by Hamlet. There follows a soliloquy in which Hamlet marvels at the power of theater and recalls something he has heard, to the effect that 'guilty creatures sitting at a play/Have by the very cunning of the scene/Been strook so to the soul, that presently/They have proclaim'd their malefactions' (II.ii.589–92), whence his plan to observe Claudius' reaction to the play. The scene (and act) closes with a rhyming couplet in which Hamlet sums up the plan and its desired effect by observing that ' … the play's the thing/Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the King' (II.ii.604–605).

There is of course nothing unusual about rhyming scene-ending couplets,[2] and Hamlet's propensity for puns and other forms of wordplay is too well known to require extensive comment.[3] The purpose of this note is to suggest the possibility of a hitherto unrecognized pun in the scene-ending rhyme just cited, involving at least one of two earlier specialized meanings of the word *thing*. This word is abundantly attested in the work of Shakespeare, essentially in its modern usage. But uniquely in this instance,[4] and in a way that would be highly appropriate to the context, we may also have a latent punning sense (*Oxford English Dictionary* Online **1.1.** under **thing**, NOUN[1]) 'A meeting, an assembly; *esp.* a deliberative or judicial assembly, a court, a council' (the etymological meaning, well documented for Old English *þing* and cognates in Old Norse, Old High German, and elsewhere in Germanic), or else the narrower judicial sense (*OED* Online **1.2.a.**) 'A cause; *spec.* a matter brought before a court of law; a charge brought.' No meaning of this kind for *thing* is registered in any of the standard Shakespeare glossaries or lexica.[5]

The first of these ('(deliberative or judicial) assembly') would incorporate a significant instance of semantic postdating, not unlike (though chronologically more extreme than) another such postdating highlighted by Weiskott for *Twelfth Night* (1600–01),[6] composed about the same time as *Hamlet*. Despite the absence of this sense in some Middle English dictionaries[7] or the claim (especially in some internet resources) that such a meaning 'did not survive the shift to Middle English'[8] or 'disappeared by early Middle English',[9] an attestation of the word with this meaning is found as a gloss in Roger of Hoveden's (Latin) *Chronicle* (1200),[10] as well as a possible instance as late as

[1] The original date of composition is unclear, but is thought to have been around 1600. Quotations of *Hamlet* are from *The Riverside Shakespeare*, ed. G. Blakemore Evans, 2nd edn (Boston, MA, 1997). The textual history of the play is notoriously complex; see conveniently the 'Textual Introduction' to the play in *The Norton Shakespeare*, ed. Stephen Greenblatt, 3rd edn (New York, 2016), 1760–3. Hence alternate line references: II.ii.604 (in the title of this note) corresponds to II.ii.523 in the Norton edition.

[2] See, for example, Gilles Mathis, 'Looking for Rhyme and Prosodic Patterning in *Richard III*', *Bulletin de la société d'études anglo-américaines des XVIIe et XVIIIe siècles*, xlix (1999), 77–110, 86: 14 of 25 scenes in *Richard III* end on rhymes (here also with comparative notes on the scene-end rhyming practice in other plays).

[3] In addition to the classic treatment by M. M. Mahood, *Shakespeare's Wordplay* (London, 1957), especially Ch. V (*Hamlet*), see also George T. Wright, 'Hendiadys and Hamlet', *PMLA* xcvi (1981), 168–93; Teresa Hooper, 'Dangerous Doubles: Puns and Language in Shakespeare's *Hamlet*', *Chrestomathy: Annual Review of Undergraduate Research at the College of Charleston* ii (2003), 120–34; Martina Bross, '"Equivocation Will Undo Us"? Wordplay and Ambiguity in Hamlet's First and Second Line", in Angelika Zirker and Esme Winter-Froemel (eds.) *Wordplay and Metalinguistic/Metadiscursive Reflection* (Berlin, 2015), 25–45.

[4] Possibly also in a later *Hamlet* instance, discussed below.

[5] For example (all s.v. *thing*) Alexander Dyce, *A General Glossary to Shakespeare's Works* (Boston, MA, 1904); Alexander Schmidt, *Shakespeare-Lexicon*, rev. Gregor Sarrazin, 4th edn (Berlin, 1923); C. T. Onions, *A Shakespeare Glossary*, rev. Robert D. Eagleson, rev. edn (Oxford, 1986); David Crystal and Ben Crystal, *Shakespeare's Words: A Glossary and Language Companion* (London, 2002).

[6] Eric Weiskott, 'A Postdating of *throw* 'time' in *Twelfth Night*', *Notes and Queries* lxiii (2016), 421–2.

[7] For example, Francis Henry Stratmann, *A Middle English Dictionary: Containing Words Used by English Writers from the Twelfth to the Fifteenth Century*, rev. Henry Bradley (Oxford, 1891), 634, s.v. *þing*.

[8] *Wikipedia* s.v. "Thing (assembly)" (www.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thing_(assembly)).

[9] *Online Etymology Dictionary* ("Etymonline", www.etymonline.com), s.v. *thing*.

[10] *Chron.* II.233: In quibusdam vero provinciis Anglici vocant *lede* quod isti [scil. Danes] *þinge* dicunt.

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1398. The latter is cited both by the *Middle English Dictionary* Online under sense #15 for *thing* ('A council; also, an assembly convened for judicial purposes') and by the *OED* Online under **thing**, NOUN[1], **1.1.** (cf. above), from John of Trevisa's translation (1398) of Bartholomaeus Anglicus's *De Proprietatibus Rerum*. The text of this passage, however, is not altogether clear. In Capitulum *lxi* ('De Frisia'), the sentence in question reads (according to *MED* and *OED*): 'But þey ben sogette to þinges þat þey chesen of hem self from ȝeere to ȝeere þat releueþ þe comunete among hem'. Seymour's critical text of the passage, however, offers two emendations, namely (and very plausibly) 'reuleþ' 'rules' for what appears to be 'releueþ' 'relieves, supports', and for 'þinges' (attested in multiple manuscripts) a more complex emendation 'þe iuges' 'the judges'.[11] The corresponding Latin of Bartholomaeus, to be sure, reads *iudicibus* 'judges' for the word in question, although other factors (including the significant manuscript support) render 'þinges' 'judicial councils or assemblies' perhaps equally possible. Still, even accepting this late 14th century attestation of ME *þing* in a meaning like 'judicial council', one may hesitate to credit that for the purpose of this pun Shakespeare availed himself of a meaning of *thing* that had gone out of use well over a century earlier. This could perhaps be mitigated by one or both of the following considerations. The same sense of *thing* appears in the second member of the compound *husting* (now mainly plural),[12] in its earlier meaning referring to a court of common pleas (well attested through Middle English and later, held in London and other cities). Moreover, the institution of the *thing* (referring to a public assembly) was memorialized in a number of recurring toponyms throughout the British Isles originally referring to the location of public assemblies (in many such places still held in the 15th and 16th centuries), such as Thingwall (literally 'thing field') in Merseyside, Tingwall (in Shetland),[13] and many more,[14] at least some of which may have been semantically transparent, if only to local populations. Certainty about the intuitions of Elizabethan native speakers is perhaps unattainable in this case; but it seems at least possible that material of this kind may have supported knowledge about the widespread institution of the *thing* in Germanic-speaking lands (including early England) at least among some speakers of Shakespeare's time.

One can perhaps accept more readily the second proposed sense of *thing* referring to a charge brought before a court of law, documented well into the 16th century, with fixed phrasing (mirroring Old English usage) that involves 'answering unto things (i.e., charges) that have been laid against or objected to' a person; so also in the verb OE *þingian* (ME *thingen*) 'to make a plea, intercede' and the OE compound *þingleás* '*thingless*, i.e. exempt (from a criminal charge)', similarly Old Frisian *thinglās* 'without recourse to a court of law'. This sense of *thing* as 'criminal charge' is documented in all three of the *OED*-cited instances from the 15th and 16th centuries. The latest of these[15] is particularly significant, as it appears in the Henry VI portion of Edward Hall's *The Union of the Two Noble and Illustre Famelies of Lancastre and Yorke* ('Hall's Union'), published in 1548 and one of the sources for Shakespeare's Henry VI trilogy.[16] An 18th-century discussion of this meaning helpfully ties together this usage with other material seen above: '… what the Greeks called *πραγμα* a Cause, the Saxons and Danes called a *Thing* or *litigated Cause*; and the Lawyers *Thingmen*, a Judge *Thingrave*, and the Court, *Husthing* or the House for hearing Law Causes: Hence the Court of the Lord Mayor of London is called *the Hustings* or *House of Things*, i.e. *Causes*'.[17]

Both of these senses of *thing* have an obvious fitness for the context of Hamlet's statement about his theatrical scheme to reveal Claudius' guilt: ' … the play's the thing [*public* (esp. judicial) *assembly*, or *charge brought before a court*]/Wherein I'll catch

[11] M. C. Seymour (ed.), *On the Properties of Things: John Trevisa's Translation of Bartholomaeus Anglicus, De Proprietatibus Rerum: A Critical Text*, vol. 2, Book XV (Oxford, 1975; online 2019).

[12] From Old Norse *hūsþing* (*hūs* 'house' + *þing* 'assembly').

[13] For these 'thing + field' compound toponyms, cf. Icelandic *Þingvellir* ('assembly fields'), the original location of the *Alþingi* ('general assembly'), the ancient (and still modern) parliamentary body of Iceland (930 CE+).

[14] More than a dozen such place names are listed (along with a few surnames), with Middle English attestations, at *MED* Online s.v. *thing*, sense #16 ("In surname and place names").

[15] "The duke … sufficiently answered to all thynges to him obiected" (*Hall's Vnion: Henry VI* f. clj).

[16] See in detail W. Gordon Zeeveld, 'The Influence of Hall on Shakespeare's English Historical Plays', *ELH* iii (1936), 317–53.

[17] John Pettingal, *An Enquiry into the Use and Practice of Juries among the Greeks and Romans* (London, 1769), 1.61.

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the conscience of the King'. Especially for the first of these senses, which may involve a significant postdating, one can follow the lead of Weiskott, who noted (in his own account of an instance of postdating in *Twelfth Night*) that 'The pun probably also explains why Shakespeare reached for this obsolescent word in 1600 or 1601'.[18] In the final analysis, the pun on *thing* proposed here, having eluded recognition for at least several centuries, may have to be considered an instance of 'secret wordplay', in the sense of Bauer,[19] all of the features of which it neatly fulfills, this one above all: 'When secret wordplay is noticed, it is found to enhance the meaning of the text'.[20] One can also add that the prominence of 'thing' (in the suggested senses) in Old Norse language and culture has an obvious appropriateness, in purely geographical terms, for 'Hamlet the Dane'.

The pattern '(the) X is/X's the thing' does not otherwise occur in Shakespeare. But an instance of the pattern 'the X is a thing' (with indefinite article) occurs later in *Hamlet*, and could conceivably be a reminiscence of our passage, with a glancing reference to one of the secondary meanings of *thing* suggested here. During Hamlet's enigmatic exchange with Rosencrantz and Guildenstern in Act IV, he states, 'The king is a thing—' (IV.ii.28), to the evident puzzlement of Guildenstern, who replies, 'A thing, my lord?'. We thus hear the same rhyme on *king* and *thing*, only in reversed order as compared with Hamlet's earlier scene-ending couplet (' … thing/ … king'). What does Hamlet mean by this? He replies to Guildenstern's query by saying, 'Of nothing.', which only deepens the mystery of what he intends. Commentators have little to say about this exchange; suggestions range from the superficial observation that if the king is 'a thing … of nothing' Hamlet considers the king of no account, possibly hinting that his days are numbered,[21] to much more elaborate notions associating old King Hamlet (the rightful king who nevertheless is a ghost, thus 'a thing of nothing') with the illegitimate rule of Claudius (thus also 'a thing of nothing').[22] One hesitates to read too much into punctuation;[23] but while most editors print the dash after Hamlet's 'The king is a thing' (the punctuation of F1), preceding what appears to be an interruption by Guildenstern, one could argue that the alternate punctuation with a period (the reading of Q2–4)[24] fits better with Guildenstern's puzzled query, which elicits from Hamlet a corrective response (with typical wordplay) *as if* he was interrupted. But now that Hamlet is convinced of Claudius' guilt, having witnessed his reaction to 'The Murder of Gonzago', 'The king is a thing'—especially as an end-stopped declarative statement—might carry a resonance of a secondary sense of *thing* as suggested above for the proposed pun at II.ii.604, perhaps with a meaning like 'The king is [someone to answer for] a criminal charge'.

Brent Vine
University of California, Los Angeles, USA

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[18] Weiskott, op. cit. (n 6), 422. For insightful discussion of Shakespeare's punning styles, see Magdalena Adamczyk, '"Better a witty fool than a foolish wit": On Punning Styles of Shakespeare's Pedants and Jesters', *Journal of English Studies* xi (2013), 7–25. There is, of course, voluminous literature on Shakespeare's puns; in addition to the references in n 3 above, see, for example, S. S. Hussey, *The Literary Language of Shakespeare* (New York, 1982), 139–41; Dirk Delabastita, 'Wholes and Holes in the Study of Shakespeare's Wordplay', in Mireille Ravassat and Jonathan Culpeper, *Stylistics and Shakespeare's Language: Transdisciplinary Approaches* (London, 2011), 139–62; Margaret Ferguson, 'Fatal Cleopatras and Golden Apples: Economies of Wordplay in Some Shakespearean "Numbers"', in Jonathan F. S. Post (ed.), *The Oxford Handbook of Shakespeare's Poetry* (Oxford, 2013); Douglas Bruster and Nell McKeown, 'Wordplay in Earliest Shakespeare', *Philological Quarterly* xcvi (2017), 293–322.

[19] Matthias Bauer, 'Secret Wordplay and What It May Tell Us', in Angelika Zirker and Esme Winter-Froemel (eds.) *Wordplay and Metalinguistic/Metadiscursive Reflection* (Berlin, 2015), 269–88.

[20] Bauer (n 19), 269.

[21] Thus Dover Wilson, as cited ad loc. in *The Riverside Shakespeare* (n 1 above), 1218.

[22] Leona Grujić, "Mannerist Features in *Hamlet*", Diplomski Rad, Odsjek za anglistiku, Filozofski fakultet (Zagreb, 2017), 17.

[23] See in general David Crystal's Chapter 4 ('"Know my stops": Shakespearean Punctuation') in "*Think on my words": Exploring Shakespeare's Language* (Cambridge, 2008), and further Peter Kanelos, '"If I break time": Shakespearean Line Endings on the Page and the Stage", in Mireille Ravassat and Jonathan Culpeper, *Stylistics and Shakespeare's Language: Transdisciplinary Approaches* (London, 2011), 84–97, 90 (on punctuation in Renaissance manuals of rhetoric).

[24] This textual variation is reported, for example, in the apparatus at *The Riverside Shakespeare*, 1242.

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